

Queen bee

In a honeybee colony, the queen will mate with various males to ensure a good mix of genes.

Over the next few years she will lay up to 2,000 eggs a day—that's more than her own body weight! Some eggs are fertilized and go on to become female workers, and some are unfertilized and become male drones.

Workers perform a special “waggle dance” to communicate to each other where a food source can be found.

Older workers go out to collect pollen and nectar.

Younger workers clean the hive and feed the larvae.

Larvae fed solely on royal jelly will develop into a queen bee.

The QUEEN is surrounded by workers who meet her every need.

Mole rats

The only vertebrates that live in this type of colony are two species of mole rats. Their colonies are not as big as insect groups and have a more equal mix of males and females. The mole rats vary in size with the smallest ones doing most of the hard labor. By the time they reach full size they do no work but are responsible for guarding the nest, defending it to the death if necessary.

As they get older and bigger they work less hard, spending more time lounging in the central nest chamber.

Pheew, this is hard work—I can't wait to grow up and get some rest!

The smallest are the hardest workers, digging and cleaning tunnels.

They work in a production line, kicking dirt along and out to the surface.

Only the queen breeds, handing over the pups to the workers to raise. She spends most of her time patrolling the tunnels, checking on the workers.

Life in the colony

